

According to Table 7.10, the lowest language literacy rate is reported in Batticaloa District (92.7%). Also, literacy rates exceeding 98 percent are reported from Gampaha, Colombo, Kalutara, Mannar, Jaffna, Kurunegala, and Kegalle. Regarding English language literacy, the highest rate is observed in Colombo (74.2%), while the minimum value is reported in Mullaitivu district (31.7%). The literacy rates for Sinhala and Tamil vary by district, a trend likely influenced by the distribution of ethnic groups.

Language Literacy by Ethnic Group

Table 7.11 : Language Literacy Rate by Language and Ethnic Group, 2012 and 2024

Ethnic Group	Literacy rate %							
	Sinhala		Tamil		English		Language Literacy	
	2012	2024	2012	2024	2012	2024	2012	2024
Sri Lanka	79.7	85.2	26.4	45.3	30.8	57.3	95.7	97.4
Sinhala	96.4	97.8	5.3	29.2	31.1	58.6	96.5	98.1
Sri Lanka Tamil	17.3	36.3	94.1	94.0	24.3	45.2	94.3	95.6
Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar	20.9	40.8	86.2	90.0	19.4	44.6	86.4	91.1
Sri Lanka Moor/Muslim	40.6	62.5	94.8	94.5	38.7	65.4	95.0	96.8
Burgher	77.0	81.8	29.1	53.8	97.4	79.3	98.2	98.0
Malay	81.8	92.7	97.1	70.9	66.8	85.4	97.6	98.1
Other	54.1	56.1	38.3	33.1	80.8	70.2	95.0	89.9

According to Table 7.11, an analysis of language literacy rates for the population aged 10 and over by ethnic group reveals that Sinhala language literacy rate in 2024 has increased across all ethnic groups relative to the 2012 census. Similarly, the Tamil language literacy rate of the Sinhalese, Indian Tamil/Malaiyaga Thamilar and Burgher ethnic groups shows an increase compared to 2012. Furthermore, excluding the Burgher ethnic group all other ethnicities demonstrate a significant upward trend in English language literacy rate in 2024.

Computer and Digital Literacy

In the Census of Population and Housing 2024, in addition to language literacy, information was also collected on the computer literacy and digital literacy of persons aged 5 years and over in Sri Lanka. While computer literacy information was previously collected during the 2012 Census, for the first time, information on digital literacy was collected in this census.

Computer Literacy

Computer literacy was defined as the “ability of an individual aged 5 years and over to independently power on a computer and perform a specific task using it”. Furthermore, an individual is considered computer literate if they can execute at least one basic activity, such as playing a computer game, without external assistance.

Digital Literacy

"An individual aged 5 years and over is considered to have digital literacy if they demonstrate the ability to perform any task using a computer (Laptop, Desktop, or Minicomputer) or a smartphone."

Computer Literacy Rate

The computer literacy rate is defined as the total number of computer-literate individuals expressed as a percentage of the total population aged 5 years and over.